

Nakajima Ki-84-Ia Hayate ("Frank")

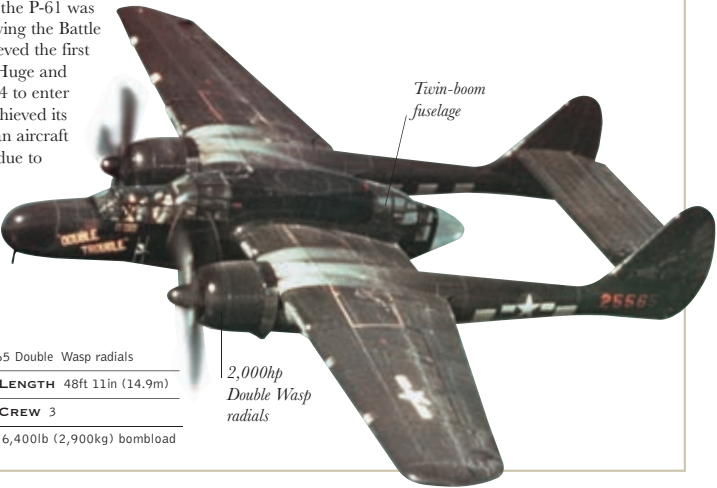
Japanese fighter aircraft achieved their fearsome reputation by concentrating on maneuverability and speed over heavy armament. The introduction of the Ki-84 in 1944 brought a fast, heavily armed, and rugged machine that could outperform both the Hellcat and the Mustang. Fortunately for the Allies, heavy bombing reduced the quantity of aircraft produced and the quality of those that did reach the front line.



ENGINE 1,900hp Nakajima Ha-45 air-cooled 18-cylinder radial	
WINGSPAN 36ft 10in (11.2m)	LENGTH 32ft 6in (9.9m)
TOP SPEED 392mph (631kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 2 x 12.7mm machine guns, 2 x 20mm cannon	

Northrop P-61A Black Widow

The first aircraft ever designed explicitly as a radar-equipped night fighter, the P-61 was ordered by the US Army following the Battle of Britain, when the RAF achieved the first successful radar interceptions. Huge and complex, it took until May 1944 to enter service – two months later it achieved its first kill. Surprisingly agile for an aircraft the size of a medium bomber, due to the innovative control systems devised by Northrop, it packed a devastating punch. Its large bombload meant that it was often used on “intruder” missions.



ENGINE 2 x 2,250hp P&W R-2800-65 Double Wasp radials	
WINGSPAN 66ft 1in (20.1m)	LENGTH 48ft 11in (14.9m)
TOP SPEED 366mph (589kph)	CREW 3
ARMAMENT 4 x 20mm M2 cannon; 6,400lb (2,900kg) bombload	

North American P-51D Mustang

The Mustang, designed by North American Aviation to a British specification, was WWII's outstanding long-range fighter. Its first flight was in October 1940, and initially it was equipped with an Allison engine. However, the Mustang's performance was transformed after it was equipped with a Packard Merlin engine. This, combined with its low-drag wing and fuselage allowed it to fly faster and further than the Spitfire. In October 1943, the US strategic bombing campaign, using unescorted B-17s and B-24s, was suspended after high losses, but in February 1944, it was resumed with Mustangs escorting the bombing raids. Equipped with drop tanks, the P-51 could fly as far as Berlin, and, even at this range, its performance was superior to most German fighters.



ENGINE 1,490hp Packard V-1650-7 Merlin liquid-cooled V-12 cylinder	
WINGSPAN 37ft (11.9m)	LENGTH 32ft 3in (9.9m)
TOP SPEED 437mph (703kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 6 x .5in Browning machine guns; 2 x 1,000lb (454kg) bombs	

Republic P-47 Thunderbolt

Introduced in 1943, the P-47 was then the largest and heaviest single-seat fighter ever built. Originally used as an escort fighter for the US 8th Air Force's strategic bombing offensive, the Thunderbolt's tough construction and heavy firepower allowed it to devastate German armor, troops, transport systems, and airfields in close support of the American armies during 1944–5.



ENGINE 2,300hp Pratt & Whitney R-2800 radial with turbocharger	
WINGSPAN 40ft 9in (12.4m)	LENGTH 36ft 1in (11m)
TOP SPEED 429mph (690kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 8 x .5in machine guns; 2,000lb (907kg) bombload	

Yakovlev Yak-9

The Yak-1 series of fighters, to which the Yak-9 belongs, eventually numbered nearly 37,000 examples, almost as many as the Il-2 Shturmovik. When the two-seat trainer developed for the Yak-1 was found to handle better than the parent aircraft, it was built as a fighter in its own right: the Yak-7. This in turn became the Yak-9 after mid-1942, when light alloy wing spars replaced wood, giving room for increased payload. Many variants were produced, including the 9D (long range) and 9DD (very long range). The Yak-9, in considerable numbers, made a decisive contribution to the victory at Stalingrad at the end of 1943.



ENGINE 1,260hp Klimov VK-105PF liquid-cooled V-12 cylinder	
WINGSPAN 32ft 9in (10m)	LENGTH 28ft (8.5m)
TOP SPEED 372mph (599kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 1 x 20mm ShVAK cannon firing through propeller hub, 2 x 12.7mm BS machine guns above engine	